

ARE THESE
COOKIES AS



SWEET

AS THEY

SEEM?

This website uses cookies

blah blah blah data, we want to
track your internet movement blah
blah blah oooo big green button!!
press it!! we want your data soooo
bad... pleaseeeeee come on....

Manage
Cookies

ACCEPT :D

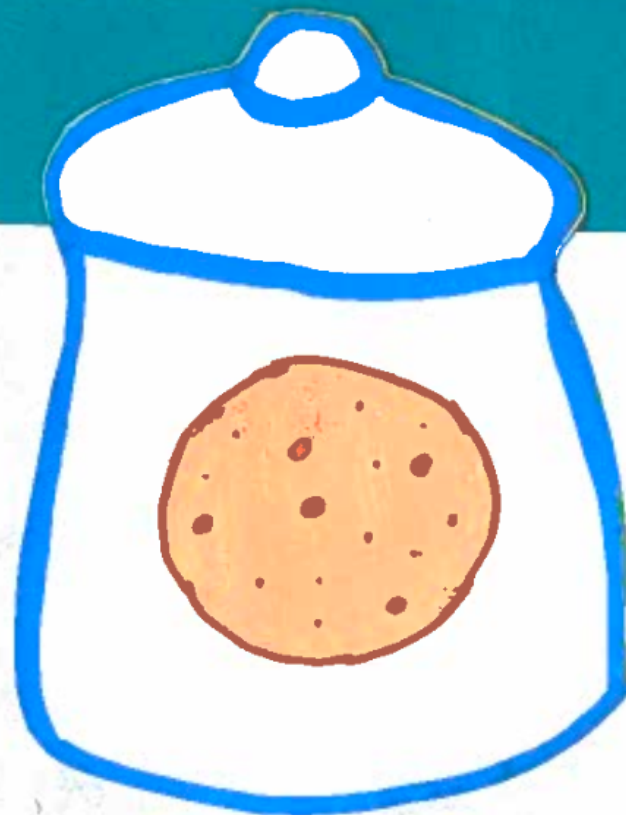
We've all been there: you're on a
deadly hunt for an answer to your
urgent question (academic?
cooking? medical? maybe you are
dying?).... You click on the
first link and you are met with
an immediate pop-up, asking you
to accept the website's cookies.
Due to the urgency of your needs,
you accept (duh)! You receive the
information you are looking for
(your symptoms are normal, again,
phew), you continue browsing the
web, check your socials, maybe do
a little shopping, no big deal.

Cookie banners have become so normal to us, have you ever wondered what these digital cookies actually are or what they do? And why is it so much more work to decline or manage them? Look no further! This zine seeks to explain what cookies are, and how knowledge is essential in taking control of your data. Try to think more critically about digital privacy and surveillance, and how everyday internet users are subtly manipulated through data tracking.

Contents

- into the cookie jar
- when the chocolate chip is actually a raisin
- beware how the cookie may crumble

Part one



↪ INTO THE
COOKIE JAR



* spoiler alert *
this zine is NOT
about actual
cookies...

these cookies are digital —

teeny tiny pieces of data
that get saved by browsers

but what exactly
is being saved?



- * the user's IP address
- * how long they spend on specific webpages
- * what users are searching
- * shopping preferences
- * links and buttons clicked

... among others¹

Originally designed for privacy, cookies became tracking tools between 1994 and 1997, driven by the marketing industry.² As they became widespread, they were seen as natural and unavoidable. Many users are likely unaware of the fact that their activity is not only being tracked on one specific website, but rather across various sites and platforms. This lack of awareness plays a crucial role in the normalization of digital surveillance, reinforcing the power of advertising-driven data collection.²

cookies collect data, and this data represents what we do and who we are.³ The data we create feeds corporate and government surveillance; while users are seemingly 'freely' engaging online, they are also giving companies and agencies the power to shape our decisions, and track our behaviours.³





So you're telling
me... these cookies
are NOT treats??
I feel so deceived...

Yeah... Kinda strange right?

But I guess calling
them something like
"trackers" might
not sound as good!



When I picture
them like this,
how could
I say no?

Part

2.

When the
Chocolate chip
is actually
a Raisin...

When you mindlessly accept a
webpages cookies, you may
think you're getting this...



But really, you're getting
something more like this



The term "cookie" makes digital surveillance sound cozy and harmless — but many cookies are not sweet at all. They can disguise invasive tracking behind a sugary name, making it harder for users to see the risks baked in. Working as a metaphor to describe the small pieces of data stored by a website (crumbs!), "cookies" could be viewed as watering down their purpose.

It's important to understand the genealogy of metaphors, and also to call attention when they are misleading.⁴

Although not all cookies are bad or misleading to users, the language used is interesting as it suggests something harmless, or even desirable, instead of something that could be tied to data collection and behavioural profiling.^{5,6}

★ Some cookies are necessary, but not all cookies are created equally (see: raisin on the left). There are types that are used for more elusive reasons, which users should be aware of. ⁶

Necessary Cookies = Chocolate chips

These help the website function, and usually are placed by the website owner. They may help remember your username, what's in your cart, or your language preferences. ⁷

Non-Essential Cookies = Hidden Raisins

These are used to watch how users interact with a site: either analytical or advertisement-based, and often third party cookies placed by other companies for personalized ads and building profiles for users. ⁷



PART 3:



BEWARE!

of how the cookie

may crumble

When you click
"accept all", it might
feel like you're just
unlocking a site
feature —

but you're actually
opening the door to
a chain reaction of data
collection, sharing +
surveillance.¹

You may have recognized the cookie
banner pop-up on Page 2...

These banners have become very
common online, often featuring a
great, big, enticing green "accept"
button and a much smaller option
for users to manage their cookie
preferences.⁴ As a result of the
convenience of one button to get rid of
the pop-up rather than a series of
buttons, users are more likely to
accept non-essential cookies.⁸

When accepting cookies, many users focus on
short-term benefits, like quickly accessing
content or getting rid of pop-ups.⁸

Did you
Know:

When presented with consent about user privacy rights or cookie options, most people skip the details and spend only about 13 seconds before proceeding!¹

cookies are the most widespread digital tool contributing to online surveillance capitalism.²



A term coined by Shoshana Zuboff to describe how companies collect, analyze, and profit from personal data by predicting and influencing human behaviour.¹⁰

Shhh...
I'm shopping...
need new
UFO decor...





Surveillance capitalism doesn't stop at your browser. As Zuboff (2015) warns, your phone, computer, and smart devices form a vast web of data extraction.¹⁰ What starts as a harmless-looking cookie becomes part of an entire system designed to watch, predict, and profit from your behaviour.

that **accept all** button is just the tip of a very big, invisible iceberg.

Now You Know What's in The Cookie

You've seen behind the banner and learned how cookies can be part of a sprawling system of surveillance capitalism — this is a system that collects our behaviours, analyzes our patterns, and monetizes our attention.

It all starts with something as ordinary as a website pop-up asking for your consent.

BUT... You don't have to keep saying yes

your data is valuable, don't give it away for free!!



What **you** can do:

- Say no to non-essential cookies, take the extra steps!
- Install privacy tools (I use ublock origin :))
- actually read cookie banners, you never know what you might be consenting to
- Spread the word!
Normalize talking about digital privacy



Wow! I learned
soo much about
cookies! And also...
I'm kinda hungry
now...

By unpacking the metaphors, manipulations, and mechanics of online tracking, this zine aims to spark critical thinking and curiosity and give the readers the tools to better navigate the web.

Want to learn more?

2 READ:

1. Ferrari, B. (2021). 'It's Bad Design On Purpose' – Why Website Cookie Banners Look Like That. Vice.
2. Zuboff, S. (2015). *Big Other: Surveillance Capitalism and the Prospects of an Information Civilization*

Great pieces on cookies, digital surveillance etc.

3. film that explores how platforms manipulate data.
4. digital resource all about cookies.
5. website that summarizes terms and privacy policies of other websites!

EXPLORE:

3. *The Social Dilemma* (2020). Available on Netflix!
4. Knowcookies.com (<https://knowcookies.com/>)
5. Terms of Service; Didn't Read (<https://tosdr.org/en>)

Cited Sources

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<https://doi-org.libaccess.lib.mcmaster.ca/10.9783/9780812299946-010>
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<https://doi-org.libaccess.lib.mcmaster.ca/10.7551/mitpress/9302.003.0002>
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- 9 Stoycheff, E. (2023). Cookies and content moderation: affective chilling effects of internet surveillance and censorship. *Journal of Information Technology & Politics*, 20(2), 113-124.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/19331681.2022.2063215>
- 10 Zuboff, S. (2015). Big other: Surveillance Capitalism and the Prospects of an Information Civilization. *Journal of Information Technology*, 30(1), 75-89.
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